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Puzzles of EU and NATO Accession of Post-Communist Countries

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ABSTRACT *Accessions of post-communist countries to the European Union (EU) and the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO) represent puzzles. While many such countries were granted a membership or a prospect of membership in these organisations, other European post-communist countries were not offered accession or the prospect of membership in the EU and NATO. The question is which factors account for such significant variation in accession to the EU and NATO among European post-communist countries. This article uses statistical analysis to determine which factors affect the accession of 25 European post-communist states to the EU and NATO in 1997–2010. The study shows that the level of democracy is positively associated with accession to NATO and the EU. Conflicts have a negative impact on the NATO enlargement, while the level of economic development has a positive effect on EU enlargement. Being a post-Soviet country has a negative effect on both NATO and EU accession.*

KEY WORDS: European Union, NATO, enlargement policy, post-communist countries, post-Soviet countries

Introduction

Enlargements of the European Union (EU) and the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO) present puzzles when it comes to the accession of post-communist countries. Some European post-communist countries have made significantly more and faster progress in their accession to these organisations than other countries. For example, the EU launched membership negotiations with the Czech Republic, Estonia, Hungary, Poland, and Slovenia in 1998 and with Romania, Slovakia, Latvia, Lithuania, and Bulgaria in 1999. These countries, with the exception of Bulgaria and Romania, were the first group of post-communist states that joined the European Union in 2004. Bulgaria and Romania followed in 2007. The next wave of EU enlargement focused on the remaining countries of ex-Yugoslavia and Albania. In a series of official policy documents and public proclamations since 2000, the EU identified such states as Albania, Croatia, Serbia,

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Macedonia, Montenegro, Bosnia, and Kosovo as potential candidates or official candidates for European Union membership (see European Commission, 2011).

Similarly, the Czech Republic, Hungary, and Poland were the first post-communist countries that were invited at the NATO Summit in Madrid in 1997 to start negotiations concerning their membership in the military alliance, and then to join NATO in 1999. Bulgaria, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Romania, Slovakia, and Slovenia became NATO members in 2004. Albania and Croatia achieved the same status in 2009, while such ex-Yugoslav states as Bosnia, Macedonia, and Montenegro were offered NATO Membership Action Plans (see NATO, 2011).

In contrast, many other post-communist countries located fully or partly in Europe, such as Russia, Belarus, Moldova, Azerbaijan, and Kazakhstan, were not even offered the prospect of membership in these organisations in the future if they were to satisfy all official criteria for joining the EU and NATO. Ukraine and Georgia were officially recognised as potential members of NATO, but not the European Union. Such differences are puzzling since all these countries shared similar communist legacies, and their European Union and NATO accessions became possible about the same time as a result of a collapse of communism and the break-up of the Soviet Union, Yugoslavia, and Czechoslovakia at the end of the 1980s and the beginning of the 1990s.

What factors account for such significant variation in accession to the EU and NATO among European post-communist countries? Previous studies primarily examined accession or non-accession of individual post-communist countries or relatively small groups of these countries. The number of quantitative analyses of determinants of accession for all post-communist states that qualified or can potentially qualify for EU and NATO membership is limited, and many existing studies do not take into account important developments since the beginning of the 2000s, in particular, accession progress of such countries of ex-Yugoslavia as Croatia, Bosnia, Macedonia, Montenegro, and Serbia (see, for example, Schimmelfennig, 2001; Schimmelfennig & Sedelmeier, 2005).

This paper analyses factors which affect the progress towards accession to the EU and NATO of 25 post-communist countries that are considered fully or partly European. The study first specifies hypotheses concerning determinants of the EU and NATO enlargements. The next section reviews previous research on the potential factors of the enlargement. It then proceeds with description of the data and methodology and results of multiple regression analysis.

This paper tests several hypotheses which are based both on official criteria of the enlargement of these organisations and on previous studies which identified other factors of EU and NATO accession. The first hypothesis is that the level of democracy is a major determinant of the EU and NATO accession of the post-communist states. Both EU and NATO membership criteria and previous studies underline the importance of democracy for accession to the European Union and the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation.

The second hypothesis is that cultural affinity of post-communist countries with the Western countries affects their membership prospects in the EU and NATO. Cultural affinity is defined in terms of common religious tradition and shared historical legacy. Both the European Union and NATO are often associated with Western civilisation since these organisations were founded by Western countries.

Western civilisation is frequently equated with Western Christianity (Huntington, 1996). The clash of civilisations theory implies that predominantly Protestant and Catholic post-communist nations have significantly better prospects for NATO accession compared to Muslim or Orthodox Christian countries.

Similarly, post-communist nations that have shared historical legacies with Western countries are more likely to be granted EU and NATO membership or the prospect of such membership. Political values in countries which wholly or predominantly were parts of the Austrian, Austro-Hungarian, and German empires for long historical periods are likely to be more pro-Western and closer to political values of Western members of the EU and NATO, compared with post-communist countries, which belonged to the Russian Empire and the Ottoman Empire. Previous studies show that post-communist countries that belonged to the Austrian, Austro-Hungarian, and German empires before World War I have generally been more democratic, rule-of-law oriented, successful in terms of economic reforms and economic development, and less corrupt than countries which belonged to the Russian Empire and the Ottoman Empire (see Katchanovski, 2000; Pop-Eleches, 2007). Similar historical legacies are major determinants of pro-Western orientations and political values in regions of post-Soviet Ukraine. Several western Ukrainian regions which experienced Austrian rule before World War I are consistently much more likely to favour the pro-Western orientation of this post-Soviet country compared to other regions that experienced Russian or Ottoman rule during the same historical time period (see, for example, Birch, 2000; Katchanovski, 2006). Similarly, historical legacies affect institutional government performance in regions of Italy (Putnam, 1993).

The third hypothesis tested in this study states that Russia and other post-Soviet countries are discriminated against in terms of EU and NATO accession because of lingering prejudices in many of their major member states that exercise most influence on the enlargement process. Perceptions and policies of Western countries towards the Russian Empire and the Soviet Union historically were often very negative and irrational compared to Western perceptions and policies towards similar countries, such as the Ottoman Empire and communist China (see Davis & Trani, 2009; Malia, 1999). A number of previous studies argue that this bias, which goes back to the times of the Russian Empire and the Cold War, manifested itself in the post-Cold War policy of major Western powers towards Russia, in particular in lingering perception of Russia as a potential adversary (Lieven, 2000; Tsygankov, 2009). However, this issue is still poorly researched in academic literature in spite of its political relevance and policy significance.

The anti-Russian bias extends to post-Soviet countries to a significant degree since they, like the Soviet Union and the Russian Empire, are often associated in the West with Russia. For example, the Soviet Union and its many nationalities, in particular those that became independent in 1991, such as Ukrainians or Belarusians, were often referred to by political leaders and mass media in Western countries as 'Russia' or 'Russians'.¹ The Baltic States are exceptions because they were perceived in the West as distinct from Russia, both at the time of the Soviet Union and in the post-Soviet period.

Analysis of survey data shows that, on average, EU and NATO accession of post-Soviet countries, excluding the Baltic States, receives less public support among

leading members of these organisations than the accession of other post-communist nations. For example, in the 2009 Pew Research Centre's Global Attitudes Project survey, the unweighted average of 61% and 45% of the respondents in the United Kingdom, France, and Germany respectively favoured the admittance of Croatia and Serbia into the European Union in the next ten years. In comparison, 47% and 42% of the respondents in these three leading EU countries backed the EU membership of Ukraine and Georgia, respectively (Pew Research Centre, 2009, pp. 145–147). In the TNS Sofres Survey in November 2005, the unweighted average of 46% and 42% of respondents in the UK, France, and Germany, respectively, backed the EU membership of Ukraine and Russia when they fulfil all conditions for admission. Similarly, the 1998 Attitudes on Transatlantic Issues Survey showed that 51% and 57% of Americans supported the NATO membership of Russia and Ukraine, while 41% and 30% opposed it (respectively). In comparison, the unweighted average of 62% favoured and 26% opposed the admission of Bulgaria, Romania, Slovakia, the Czech Republic, Hungary, and Poland.

The European Union is often implicitly or explicitly equated in the West with Europe. Europe is frequently defined as a continent with no clear eastern borders (see, for instance, Pagden, 2002). Such post-Soviet countries as Russia, Ukraine, Moldova, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Georgia, Azerbaijan, and Armenia are often regarded as non-European in terms of their location and identity, and consequently as ineligible for EU and NATO membership. For example, TNS Sofres Survey in March 2005 showed that only 44% of respondents in the UK, 54% in Germany, and 63% in France consider Ukraine to be a part of Europe geographically, historically, and culturally, while 27% in the UK, 39% in Germany, and 32% in France regard Ukraine as non-European.

However, Turkey, which has a small fraction of its territory and population in Europe, was accepted into NATO, and it was granted official candidate status by the EU in contrast to Russia and Kazakhstan, which are also located partly in Europe. The European Union accepted Greek-populated Cyprus as its member although Cyprus is often located in Asia and not Europe. Likewise, Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Georgia are variously included geographically into Europe or Asia or, in the case of Georgia and Azerbaijan, a small part of their territory is often located in Europe.

In addition, the post-Soviet states are already members of other European organisations. Russia, Ukraine, Moldova, Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Georgia are members of the Council of Europe, and the right of Kazakhstan as a partly European country to join the Council of Europe is officially recognised by this organisation. All of these post-Soviet countries, along with Belarus, are also participating states of the Organisation for Security and Co-operation in Europe. As noted, the issue of the European or non-European location of Georgia did not prevent NATO from officially recognising this post-Soviet state as its potential member.

The lack of a European identity argument cannot explain the EU and NATO enlargement puzzles. Survey data show that European identity is embraced by a significant percentage of people in Russia, Ukraine, Moldova, and Belarus. For example, the proportion of the respondents who thought of themselves to at least some extent as European ranged in the 2000s between one-quarter and one-half in Russia, between one-third and one-half in Belarus, and between one-quarter and one-third in Ukraine (White et al., 2010). The levels of European self-identification

in these post-Soviet nations are comparable to many EU members (see Pilcher, 2008). For example, the 2009 Pew Research Centre's Global Attitudes Project survey demonstrates that the proportion of people in Russia (4%) and Ukraine (6%) who think of themselves first as European is not radically different from such EU members as Hungary (4%), the Czech Republic and Lithuania (6%), the United Kingdom (7%), and Bulgaria and Poland (8%) (Pew Research Centre, 2009, p. 145).

Another hypothesis tested in this study is that the level of economic development is a significant predictor of both EU and NATO enlargement among post-communist countries. Potential members with high levels of GDP per capita require less economic aid from the European Union. Similarly, post-communist countries with a higher level of economic development are more likely to satisfy the NATO condition of being able to contribute militarily.

Other factors that are considered in this study are specific to the particular organisation. Violent unsettled internal and external conflicts after the collapse of communism are expected to negatively affect accession to NATO. Population size is likely to be a negative factor in EU enlargement since the EU system of governance partly weights the power of its member states according to their population size. Because of their rational self-interest, existing EU members would be much more reluctant to support accession of countries with a large population than countries with a small population. Transition to a market economy is likely to affect positively EU accession.

Previous Studies

Researchers and policy-makers explained the exclusion of certain countries, in particular Turkey and post-communist states, by their failure to meet such formal and informal EU membership criteria as having a liberal democracy, a high level of economic development, a European location and identity, a Western Christian religion, a relatively small population size, and popular support as well as government support from the EU's prospective and most influential existing members (see, for example, Dimitrova, 2010; Fierke & Wiener, 1999; Grabbe & Hughes, 1998; Schimmelfennig & Sedelmeier, 2002). Similarly, NATO accession studies considered such criteria as democracy, Western Christianity, peaceful resolution of violent internal ethnic conflicts or territorial disputes, and the level of economic development (see Fierke & Wiener, 1999; Schimmelfennig, 2001). Large-*N* statistical analyses found that democracy was the most important factor of the EU and NATO enlargements. In contrast, effects of economic and cultural factors, and European identity and location were insignificant or mixed (see Mattli & Plumper, 2001; Schimmelfennig, 2001).

The Maastricht Treaty, adopted in 1992, specifies that any European country which respects principles set by the EU may apply to become its member.² In 1993, the European Council adopted the 'Copenhagen criteria'. To gain an EU membership, candidates are required to satisfy the following criteria:

stability of institutions guaranteeing democracy, the rule of law, human rights and respect for and protection of minorities, the existence of a functioning market economy as well as the capacity to cope with competitive pressure and

market forces within the Union. Membership presupposes the candidate's ability to take on the obligations of membership including adherence to the aims of political, economic and monetary union. The Union's capacity to absorb new members, while maintaining the momentum of European integration, is also an important consideration in the general interest of both the Union and the candidate countries.³

Similarly, the Washington Treaty, which was adopted by founding members of NATO in 1949, states that 'the Parties may, by unanimous agreement, invite any other European State in a position to further the principles of this Treaty and to contribute to the security of the North Atlantic area to accede to this Treaty'.⁴ In 1995, the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation specified in the 'Study on NATO Enlargement' that aspiring members of the alliance must be democracies, peacefully settle ethnic conflicts and territorial disputes, and be able to contribute militarily to NATO.⁵ The 'Copenhagen criteria' and the 'Study on NATO Enlargement' were issued primarily to formalise accession of potential members among post-communist states in Central and Eastern Europe.

Some studies argue that there is a reverse causation in the relationship between the level of democracy and European Union accession. Prospects of EU membership promote democratisation of post-communist countries because existence of democratic institutions is a precondition for joining the European Union (see Pevehouse, 2005; Schimmelfennig & Scholtz, 2010; Way & Levitsky, 2007). However, these studies fail to explain why the market economy conditionality in European Union accession did not have a similar effect. All European post-communist countries, both EU aspirants and countries that are not recognised as potential candidates, mostly transformed their state-controlled centrally planned economies into market economies. Other studies show that NATO accession does not promote democratisation. In spite of similar democracy conditionality in joining this organisation, it was not emphasised or strictly enforced, for instance, in the case of Portugal (see, for example, Pevehouse, 2005; Reiter, 2001).

In addition, weak support among the public and the ruling elite in such post-communist countries as Russia, Belarus, and Ukraine is often cited by scholars and policy-makers as another factor hindering their EU and NATO accession (see, for example, White et al., 2002). However, survey data show that the absolute majorities, excluding the undecided, of Russians, Belarusians, and Ukrainians consistently and by wide margins supported EU membership of their countries in the 2000s (White et al., 2010). Popular opinion concerning NATO membership in Russia, Belarus, and Ukraine varied significantly after the collapse of communism. Public opposition to NATO membership in Russia and Belarus following the NATO-led war in Kosovo and in Ukraine since the US-led war in Iraq 2003 outweighed support for joining the alliance, but public opinion on this issue in these post-Soviet states following 9/11 was in many cases split or relatively favourable (see McAllister & White, 2002; White et al., 2010).

Russian President Boris Yeltsin in 1991 and President Vladimir Putin in 2000 both voiced their desire to join NATO. Belarus, Armenia, and Kazakhstan were likely to follow Russia in joining NATO since they were Russia's allies. Even though the Russian government did not express interest in becoming a member of the European

Union, President Putin stated that he would have been pleased if Russia were to get an invitation to join this organisation since he considered Russians to be culturally and mentally European.⁶ EU membership was backed by the last three presidents of Ukraine. While Viktor Yanukovich officially renounced President Yushchenko's goal of joining NATO after becoming President of Ukraine in 2010, Yanukovich and his Party of Regions supported President Kuchma's declaration to seek such a membership in 2002.

The Georgian government after the 'Rose Revolution' in 2003 made EU and NATO membership one of its major foreign policy priorities, and the majority of the public supported this goal. In Moldova, excluding the secessionist Transdniestrian Republic, EU and NATO membership was backed by the absolute majority of people (McAllister & White, 2002; White et al., 2002). The ruling coalition, which came to power in Moldova after the July 2009 parliamentary elections, called itself the Alliance for European Integration to emphasise its foreign policy priorities. Kazakhstan and Armenian officials expressed potential interest in EU membership for their countries. Polls show that the Armenian public supported EU integration.⁷

These survey data and statements by government leaders provide an empirical basis for an assumption that there was demand for European Union integration and NATO membership among governments or/and populations of all post-communist countries, including the post-Soviet states, even though this demand was not always explicitly voiced. However, the European Union, and most leaders of its major member countries, opposed not only membership of these post-Soviet states, but also even formal recognition of the right of these countries to join this organisation in the future when they would fulfil all formal requirements for membership (see, for instance, Svyetlov, 2007).⁸ For example, the European Union's Foreign Affairs Commissioner Javier Solana stated in 2009 that Ukraine would not become an EU member in the foreseeable future, in contrast to Albania.⁹ Similarly, NATO refused to acknowledge the right of Russia and other post-Soviet states, with the exceptions of the Baltic States and Ukraine and Georgia, to join this organisation.

Such arguments as EU and NATO enlargement fatigue and geopolitical considerations are often cited as reasons for the exclusion of the post-Soviet countries. However, these arguments need to explain why during all enlargement waves since the second half of the 1990s, the excluded category was predominantly comprised of the post-Soviet states, with the exception of the Baltic States.

Such a policy of exclusion of certain post-communist countries and integration of other post-communist states represents a major puzzle for other reasons. EU and NATO membership for the post-Soviet countries would have not only offered economic, political, and security benefits to these countries, but also to members of the European Union and NATO. Mikhail Gorbachev's reforms in the Soviet Union and popular movements in its republics that later became independent states played crucial roles in the mostly peaceful end of the Cold War and the collapse of communism in the Soviet Union and Central-Eastern Europe (see, for example, Brown, 2009). In addition, Ukraine, Belarus, and Kazakhstan voluntarily renounced the nuclear weapons that were left after the collapse of the Soviet Union, while Russia significantly reduced its nuclear arsenal. The ongoing economic and security benefits to EU and NATO members from these developments outweigh potential future costs of accession of the European post-Soviet states. Moreover, the exclusion

of these states from the EU and NATO enlargement creates an economically, politically, and militarily divided Europe.

In addition, prospective members of the European Union and NATO could have promoted the peaceful resolution of conflicts involving the secessionist states of Chechnya in Russia, Transdniestria in Moldova, South Ossetia and Abkhazia in Georgia, and Nagorno Karabakh in Azerbaijan. Conflict resolution considerations were offered as a rationale for EU and NATO accession of the Balkan states, such as Bosnia, Serbia, Macedonia, and Kosovo. For example, the European Union declared Kosovo its potential member even though this secessionist state was not recognised by some EU members, such as Spain and Romania. In contrast, the EU did not offer such a prospect to similar secessionist states of Transdniestria, South Ossetia, Abkhazia, and Nagorno Karabakh.

Lasas (2010) argues that EU and NATO integration of post-communist countries was ideologically driven and presented restitution to these countries for the 1938 Munich Agreement, the 1939 Soviet–Nazi pact, and the 1945 Yalta–Potsdam conferences. However, this theory cannot explain the exclusion of such post-communist countries as Ukraine, Moldova, and Belarus from the same waves of EU and NATO enlargement since these post-Soviet countries were also affected by the Soviet–Nazi pact. In addition, the historical restitution theory fails to explain why the restitution centres on these particular World War II-related agreements and ignores World War II itself. It is puzzling that major powers of NATO and/or the EU, such as the US, the UK, and France, were reluctant to encourage NATO or EU membership of successor countries of the Soviet Union, which was allied with them during the war, and instead would reward countries, such as Hungary, Romania, Bulgaria, Slovakia, and Croatia, that were allies of Nazi Germany during the war.

Data and Methodology

Accession to the European Union and the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation is a lengthy process involving various steps. Therefore, the integration of post-communist countries into these organisations is measured with the help of indexes that reflect each major step of the accession in each year from 1997 to 2010. The EU accession index and the NATO accession index are derived from the status of each country as a member, an official candidate, an official potential candidate, and non-member/not potential candidate from 1997 to 2010. The NATO accession index ranges from 0 (non-member and not officially recognised by NATO as a potential candidate) to 3 (member country). A country which is formally recognised as a potential future member of NATO or offered an ‘Intensified Dialogue’ is given a score of 1. An official candidate country that was offered a ‘Membership Action Plan’ has a score of 2 in the NATO accession index. Similarly, the EU accession index measures the status of each post-communist country as a ‘non-member/not potential candidate’ (0), a ‘potential candidate recognised by the European Commission’ (1), an ‘official candidate’ (2), and a ‘member of the European Union’ (3) in each year from 1997 to 2010 (see Table 1).

The EU Accession Index and the NATO Accession Index are the dependent variables in a multiple regression analysis of the determinants of integration of European post-communist countries into these organisations from 1997 to 2010. The

Table 1. Dependent variables and data sources of EU and NATO accession

Variable	Description	Source
EU Accession Index	Non-member/not potential candidate of EU = 0, potential EU member = 1, official EU candidate = 2, and EU member = 3 in each year from 1997 to 2010	European Commission (2011) and Drautzburg et al. (2008)
NATO Accession Index	Non-member/not potential candidate of NATO = 0, potential NATO member or an 'Intensified Dialogue' with NATO = 1, official NATO candidate/'Membership Action Plan' = 2, and NATO member = 3 in each year from 1997 to 2010	NATO (2011) and Drautzburg et al. (2008)

cross-sectional time-series data define dependent and independent variables for each of the 25 post-communist countries for each year from 1997 to 2010.

Only countries that are regarded as fully or partially European are included in the analysis since the official criteria of both EU and NATO enlargements refer to European countries. Therefore, such Asian post-communist countries as Kyrgyzstan, Turkmenistan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, and Mongolia are excluded.

The starting date for the analysis is selected because 1997 heralded the beginning of the significant variation in the accession of post-communist countries to the European Union and NATO. The Luxembourg Summit of the EU in 1997 decided to launch in 1998 membership negotiations with the first group of candidates among post-communist countries (the Czech Republic, Estonia, Hungary, Poland, and Slovenia). Similarly, the NATO Summit in Madrid in 1997 invited the first post-communist countries (the Czech Republic, Hungary, and Poland) to begin negotiations concerning their membership in NATO.

Since the data are a combination of cross-sectional and time-series, panel regressions are used to test the hypotheses identified in the first section. The NATO and EU accession indexes, the dependent variables, are assumed to be interval-level variables. Separate regression models for the Freedom House and Polity measures of democracy are estimated. Pooled ordinary least squares (OLS) regressions and random effects regression models (RE) are employed in the analysis. Since Breusch–Pagan/Cook–Weisberg tests indicated heteroscedasticity in some of the regression models, regressions were run with robust heteroscedasticity-consistent standard errors.

The independent variables include the following: the Freedom House Democracy Index, the Polity Democracy Index, the GDP per capita (purchasing power parity), the EBRD Transition Index, religious composition of the population, Western historical legacy dummy, the post-Soviet region dummy variable, the Baltic States dummy variable, the population size, unsettled conflicts dummy, and lagged dependent variables (see Table 2). The Freedom House Democracy Index is the main measure of the level of democracy in each country for each year from 1997 to 2010. It combines political rights and civil liberties scores which are reversed so that higher value means greater level of democracy. The index ranges from 1 to 14. A linear relationship of democracy with NATO and EU enlargements is assumed.

The Polity Democracy Index is another measure of the level of democracy. The annual index ranges from –10 (most autocratic) to 10 (most democratic). This index

Table 2. Independent variables and data sources of EU and NATO accession

Variable	Description	Source
Freedom House Democracy Index	Political rights and civil liberties scores for each year in 1997–2010 (reversed)	Freedom House (2011)
Polity Democracy Index	Democracy and autocracy scores from Polity IV Project, political regime characteristics and transitions for each year in 1997–2009	Polity IV (2011)
GDP per capita (ppp), thousand \$	Gross domestic product per capita, purchasing power parity	IMF (2011)
EBRD Transition Index	A composite index derived from annual scores of large scale privatisation, small scale privatisation, governance and enterprise restructuring, price liberalisation, trade and foreign exchange system, competition policy, banking reform and interest rate, liberalisation, securities markets and non-bank financial institutions, and overall infrastructure reform	EBRD (2010)
Western Christians, %	Combined percentages of Catholics and Protestants in country's population	La Porta et al. (1999)
Western historical legacy	Dummy variable equals 1 to countries which were ruled by the Austrian Empire, the Austro-Hungarian Empire and the German Empire for at least 100 years: Croatia, the Czech Republic, Hungary, Poland, Slovakia, and Slovenia, and 0 for all other countries	Barracclough (1998), Katchanovski (2000)
Post-Soviet state	Dummy variable equals 1 for a European post-communist country that belonged to the Soviet Union, with the exception of the Baltic States (Armenia, Azerbaijan, Belarus, Georgia, Kazakhstan, Moldova, Russia, and Ukraine) and 0 for all other countries	Barracclough (1998)
Baltic State	Dummy variable equals 1 for Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania and 0 for all other countries	Barracclough (1998)
Unsettled conflicts	Dummy variable equals 1 for countries with violent conflicts which were not settled peacefully in each year in 1997–2010, and 0 otherwise	Uppsala Conflict Data Program (2011)
Population, million	Population size in each year from 1997 to 2010	IMF (2011)
Lagged EU Accession Index	One-year lag of the EU Accession Index	
Lagged NATO Accession Index	One-year lag of the NATO Accession Index	

Note: GDP and population data for Kosovo are estimated from the CIA's *World Factbook* (2010).

is used to check the robustness of the results. The Polity index is available for a shorter time period and for a smaller number of countries compared to the Freedom House index. The Polity Democracy Index covers the years from 1997 to 2009. In contrast to the Freedom House Democracy index, it is not available for 2010 and for Bosnia and Kosovo for all years.

The Western Christianity variable denotes combined percentages of Catholics and Protestants in the population. It is a measure of the Western civilisation, as defined by Huntington (1996). The Western historical legacy variable is a measure of political culture/cultural affinity. Its value is 1 for countries which were ruled by the Austrian Empire, the Austro-Hungarian Empire, and the German Empire for at least 100 years (see Table 2 and Katchanovski, 2000).

The Post-Soviet state dummy variable designates European post-communist countries that wholly or partly belonged to the Soviet Union from the date of its official establishment in 1922 to the date of its break-up in 1991. It comprises of states that were often and still are frequently associated with Russia in the West. The Baltic States dummy variable identifies three countries (Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania) that were incorporated into the Soviet Union as a result of World War II. The Baltic States were independent in the period from World War I to World War II, and their incorporation into the Soviet Union was not recognised by many Western countries.

The gross domestic product (GDP) per capita expressed at purchasing power parity is an annual measure of the level of economic development of each country in 1997–2010. The EBRD Transition Index is an annual indicator of a progress of a transition of each post-communist country to a market economy. It is the average of annual scores given by the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development to a post-communist country to assess the following elements of an economic transition: large scale privatisation, small scale privatisation, governance and enterprise restructuring, price liberalisation, trade and foreign exchange system, competition policy, banking reform and interest rate, liberalisation, securities markets and non-bank financial institutions, and overall infrastructure reform. The index ranges from 1 to 4.3. Higher values indicate a more market economy. The EBRD index and the total population size of each country in each year from 1997 to 2010 represent factors that are regarded as specific to the EU enlargement (Table 2).

Unsettled conflicts dummy variable reflects one of the official criteria of NATO accession. It denotes for each year from 1997 to 2010 countries with violent conflicts, which took place since 1991 and which were not settled peacefully. The lagged EU Accession Index and the lagged NATO Accession Index are included in the regression analysis since the accession status during each year is likely to be affected by the accession status during the previous years (see Table 2).

Multivariate Analysis

The multiple regression analysis using pooled OLS and random effects models produces similar results (Table 3). It shows that the level of democracy is positively associated with the NATO accession of the 25 post-communist countries. Both the Freedom House Democracy Index and the Polity Democracy Index have a positive effect on NATO enlargement in separate regression models. A 1 unit increase in the Freedom House democracy measure raises the accession level by 0.04 units on the scale from 0 to 3. This variable is statistically significant at the 5% level, while the Polity Democracy Index is statistically significant at the 0.1% level.

European post-Soviet countries, excluding the Baltic States, have made significantly less progress in terms of NATO accession compared to other post-communist countries when the other relevant factors, such as the level of democracy and the level of economic development, are held constant. The average post-Soviet state scores about 0.22 or 0.27 units lower than the average other country on the NATO Accession Index. The relationship is statistically significant at the 1% level in Model 1 and the 0.1% level in Model 2 (Table 3).¹⁰

Violent conflicts that are not settled peacefully negatively affect NATO enlargement. The lagged NATO Accession Index is positively associated with the

enlargement. These two variables are statistically significant in all versions of the regression models at the 1% or the 0.1% levels. Predominantly Western Christian countries do not differ significantly from other post-communist countries in their NATO accession. Similarly, the historical legacy variable is statistically insignificant in all specifications of the regression models. The level of economic development also does not have a statistically significant effect on NATO accession (see Table 3).

The Freedom House Democracy Index is positively associated with the EU accession of the European post-communist states. This variable is statistically significant at the 5% level. However, the Polity Democracy Index is statistically insignificant. Similarly, the level of GDP per capita, measured in purchasing power

Table 3. Determinants of NATO accession of European post-communist countries, regression coefficients

	Model 1		Model 2	
	Pooled OLS	Random Effects	Pooled OLS	Random Effects
Freedom House Democracy Index	0.038*	0.038*		
Polity Democracy Index			0.018***	0.018***
GDP per capita	-0.001	-0.001	0.001	0.001
Proportion of Western Christians	-0.001	-0.001	0.000	0.000
Western historical legacy	0.288	0.288	0.235	0.235
Post-Soviet country	-0.216**	-0.216**	-0.274***	-0.274***
Baltic State	0.204	0.204	0.183	0.183
Unsettled conflict	-0.189**	-0.189**	-0.255***	-0.255***
Lagged NATO accession index	0.755***	0.755***	0.741***	0.741***
Constant	0.741***	0.741***	0.446***	0.446***
R squared	0.91	0.91	0.91	0.91
N	327	327	289	289

Notes: Estimated using heteroscedasticity-consistent standard errors.

*** Statistically significant at the 0.001 level; ** statistically significant at the 0.01 level; * statistically significant at the 0.05 level; two-tailed tests.

Table 4. Determinants of EU accession of European post-communist countries, regression coefficients

	Model 1		Model 2	
	Pooled OLS	Pooled RE	Pooled OLS	Pooled RE
Freedom House Democracy Index	0.026*	0.030*		
Polity Democracy Index			0.001	0.001
GDP per capita	0.012*	0.015**	0.010	0.010
EBRD Transition Index	0.038	0.040	0.087	0.087
Proportion of Western Christians	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Western historical legacy	0.050	0.041	0.063	0.063
Post-Soviet country	-0.322***	-0.356***	-0.401***	-0.401***
Baltic State	0.122	0.132	0.127	0.127
Population size	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Lagged EU accession index	0.748***	0.706***	0.756***	0.756***
Constant	0.399*	0.449*	0.119	0.119
R squared	0.95	0.95	0.95	0.95
N	315	315	279	279

Notes: Estimated using heteroscedasticity-consistent standard errors.

*** Statistically significant at the 0.001 level; ** statistically significant at the 0.01 level; * statistically significant at the 0.05 level; two-tailed tests.

parity, has a positive effect on EU integration in Model 1, while this factor is statistically insignificant in Model 2 (Table 4).¹¹

Being a post-Soviet state, with the exception of the Baltic States, has a negative effect on European Union accession. The average post-Soviet country scores between 0.32 and 0.40 units lower on this index than the average other post-communist country. This variable is statistically significant at the 0.1% level in all specifications of the regression model (see Table 4).

With the exceptions of the lagged EU Accession Index, other determinants of European Union enlargement that are included in the regression models are statistically insignificant. Percentages of Western Christians, Western historical legacy, the population size, and the economic transition measure do not affect the European Union enlargement (Table 4).

Conclusion

The enlargements of the European Union and the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation produced major puzzles that are examined in this paper. While many post-communist countries were granted membership or the prospect of membership in these organisations, many other European post-communist countries were not offered EU and NATO membership or the prospect of membership even when they satisfied official criteria for joining these organisations. Previous studies explained the exclusion of certain post-communist countries by their failure to meet such formal and informal EU and NATO membership criteria of having a democracy, a market economy, a European location or identity, Western Christianity, a high level of economic development, popular and government support of prospective members and major existing members, a small population size in the case of EU accession, a peaceful resolution of internal ethnic conflicts or territorial disputes in case of NATO accession, and other factors.

The analysis of survey data indicates that popular opinion in major EU and NATO members is, on average, less supportive of admitting the post-Soviet countries compared to other post-communist countries. In contrast, the majorities of the respondents and governments in the post-Soviet nations back the EU membership of their countries. The support for NATO accession among the public and the governments of the post-Soviet states was generally lower and less stable. However, these factors of the EU and NATO enlargements cannot be readily included in the regression analysis.

The multivariate statistical analysis shows that level of democracy is positively associated with the EU and NATO accession of 25 European post-communist countries. The regression model which uses the Polity Index of Democracy instead of the Freedom House Democracy Index does not produce statistically significant results for the democracy measure in the case of EU enlargement. However, the Polity-based model relies on a more limited time-frame and cross-section of countries. In addition, the regression analysis cannot rule out reverse causation between EU membership and democratisation.

Being a post-Soviet country, excluding the Baltic States, has a negative effect on both European Union and NATO accessions when all other factors are held constant. However, the post-Soviet states are generally also less democratic com-

pared to other European post-communist countries. The unsettled conflicts have a negative impact on the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation enlargement. The level of economic development positively affects EU integration, but this variable becomes statistically insignificant in the Polity-based model. Other factors, such as Western Christianity and the Western historical legacy in both the EU and NATO cases, and population size and transition progress to a market economy in the case of the European Union, are not statistically significant predictors of accession.

This study implies that in contrast to other post-communist countries in Europe, post-Soviet nations, with the exception of the Baltic States, face bleak prospects for European Union and NATO integration even when they satisfy all official criteria for EU and NATO accession. A bias against post-Soviet countries indicates that such criteria, which are identified in official policies and in previous studies as the levels of democracy, are not the only important factors of the enlargement. This paper underscores the significance of the political factor that has not yet been sufficiently recognised. The study implies that Europe is likely to remain divided in the foreseeable future, in part because of the barriers that hinder accession of the post-Soviet countries to the European Union and the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation. In addition, more research is needed to explore this issue in greater depth and to examine the specifics of different stages of the EU and NATO integration of post-communist countries.

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Notes

- ¹ With exceptions of such post-Soviet countries as Kazakhstan and Russia, geography is unlikely to be a major factor since such countries as Belarus, Ukraine, and Moldova have common borders with the existing NATO and EU members, e.g. Poland, Lithuania, Slovakia, Hungary, and Romania. In addition, the NATO recognition of Georgia as a likely member of NATO implies that its geographic location and that of neighbouring countries, such as Azerbaijan and Armenia, is not a major factor.
- ² Consolidated Version of the Treaty on European Union. Available at http://eur-lex.europa.eu/en/treaties/dat/12002M/htm/C_2002325EN.000501.html (accessed 22 March 2010).
- ³ European Council in Copenhagen, 21–22 June 1993, Conclusions of the Presidency. Available at <http://europa.eu/rapid/pressReleasesAction.do?reference=DOC/93/3&format=HTML&aged=1&language=EN&guiLanguage=en> (accessed 22 March 2010).
- ⁴ The North Atlantic Treaty. Available at http://www.nato.int/cps/en/natolive/official_texts_17120.htm (accessed 26 March 2010).
- ⁵ Study on NATO Enlargement. Available at <http://www.nato.int/docu/basicxt/enl-9501.htm> (accessed 19 March 2010).
- ⁶ Putin byl by schastliv, esli Rossiia poluchit priglasenie v ES. Available at: http://www.gazeta.ru/lenta/2005/10/31/news_466019.shtml (accessed 2 May 2010).
- ⁷ Caucasus Report, 7 January, 2005. Available at <http://www.rferl.org/content/article/1341705.html> (accessed 28 March 2010).

- ⁸ In its resolution in 2010, the European Parliament recognised the right of Ukraine to potential membership in the European Union but this resolution was non-binding. See European Parliament resolution of 25 February 2010 on the situation in Ukraine. Available at <http://www.europarl.europa.eu> (accessed 14 May 2010).
- ⁹ Javier Solana's speech at Harvard University, 17 September 2009.
- ¹⁰ Partial correlations of the post-Soviet dummy variable and the Freedom House Democracy Index (−0.66) and the GDP per capita (−0.11) are statistically significant, respectively, at the 0.1% level and the 5% percent level. Partial correlations of the Post-Soviet variable with the Polity Democracy Index and GDP per capita produce similar results.
- ¹¹ The main determinants of EU and NATO accession remain the same when the log of GDP per capita is used as a measure of economic development.

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